

ACLS Course Exam Guide

The AHA ACLS Provider written exam and Megacode under the 2025 course materials: format, content, eligibility, an 8-week plan and test-day tips

THE EXAM AT A GLANCE

ITEM	2025 ACLS PROVIDER COURSE
Written exam	Proctored, online at the end of class; paper backup
Number of items	Not posted publicly by AHA; ask your instructor
Passing score	84% minimum
Time limit	Untimed per AHA's last public exam FAQ (2020); confirm locally
Open resource	Manual, your notes, ECC Handbook; no talking
Skills tests	High-quality BLS (CPR, AED), airway management, team Megacode; AHA checklists
HeartCode	Adaptive online part (exam built in), then an instructor or manikin skills session
Length	Full class 13.25 to 16.5 h; Update 8.25 to 9.5 h; HeartCode skills 6.75 to 7.75 h
Cost	Set by each Training Center; HeartCode online \$178
Card	Completion card valid 2 years, to month end

WHAT IS ON IT

AHA publishes no percentages or item counts. These areas come from the 2025 course FAQ; 2025 materials are required from March 1, 2026.

AREA	FOCUS	APP SUBJECT
Assessment and BLS	Systematic approach; early CPR and AED	BLS
Airway	Bag-mask, advanced airway, capnography	ACLS Algorithms
Cardiac arrest	VF/pVT, asystole/PEA, shocks, reversible causes	ACLS Algorithms
Brady and tachy	Rhythm ID, pacing, cardioversion	Rhythm Recognition
Medications	Arrest and peri-arrest drugs, timing	ACLS Pharmacology
ACS and stroke	Early recognition, reperfusion	ACLS Algorithms
Post-arrest care	ROSC targets, temperature control	Post-Cardiac Arrest Care
Teams, special cases	Roles, closed-loop talk, CCF; LVAD, drowning	Special Situations

EXAM TIP The exam reflects 2025 science. Know these changes:

- One 6-link Chain of Survival; SVT renamed narrow-complex tachycardia
- Sotalol dropped from the tachycardia algorithm
- Synchronized starting doses: 100 J narrow-complex or monomorphic VT; 200 J AF or flutter
- IV first, then IO; no drugs via ET tube; squeeze the bag one-third to one-half for chest rise
- Post-ROSC: MAP at least 65 mm Hg, SpO₂ 90 to 98%
- Not following commands after ROSC: 32 to 37.5 °C for at least 36 h
- Tenecteplase for stroke; LBBB alone no longer defines STEMI

SAFETY Values are typical adult figures for exam study. Follow your institution's or agency's protocols and device guidance.

WHO CAN TAKE IT

- Healthcare professionals who lead or join cardiac arrest, stroke and cardiopulmonary emergency care
- Expected skills: high-quality BLS, ECG reading, ACLS drugs, bag-mask ventilation
- BLS card: not required by AHA, though your Training Center may; some classes add one
- Classroom: Precourse Self-Assessment at 70% or higher; print and bring the report
- HeartCode: bring your online completion certificate to the skills session
- Update (renewal) course: shorter; ask your Training Center if you qualify

EXAM TIP The Precourse Self-Assessment has 3 sections: rhythm recognition, pharmacology and practical application (20 items each on the 2025 written form).

HOW TO STUDY (8 WEEKS)

1. Week 1: free AHA Precourse Self-Assessment and one app Mock Exam as baselines; start Daily Review.
2. Weeks 1 to 2: Rhythm Recognition with the Rhythm Gallery One-Pager.
3. Weeks 3 to 4: ACLS Algorithms and Pharmacology with the ACLS Algorithms in Brief One-Pager; say each next step aloud.

4. Week 5: BLS, Post-Cardiac Arrest Care, Special Situations and the Capnography One-Pager.
5. Week 6: Weakest Subject and Level Up sessions, then Missed Questions.
6. Week 7: rehearse leading Megacode cases aloud with the testing checklists in your manual's appendix; finish any prework.
7. Week 8: two full Mock Exams (aim well above 84%) and Trouble Questions.

EXAM TIP Megacode cases open with a bradycardia or tachycardia, pass through a shockable and a nonshockable arrest rhythm, and end with post-arrest care.

TEST-DAY TIPS

- Bring your passing self-assessment report or HeartCode certificate
- Bring the provider manual (print or eBook) with algorithms and drug tables tabbed
- Open resource is not open time: answer what you know, then look up flagged items
- Megacode leader: assign roles, use closed-loop talk, keep CCF above 80%, check rhythm every 2 minutes
- Not passed? Your Training Center sets remediation and retesting

OFFICIAL RESOURCES

- ACLS Provider Manual, 2025 (25-1106 print, 25-3100 eBook)
- 2025 Handbook of Emergency Cardiovascular Care (25-1100 print, 25-3105 eBook)
- ACLS Reference Cards, set of 3 (25-1120)
- Precourse Self-Assessment and Video Prework, free at elearning.heart.org
- 2025 algorithms, Guidelines Parts 9 and 11, manual change notice (August 2026)

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